

A Year after Daniel's Funeral and burial.

June, 2018

Time passes very quickly. Around this time of year is a time of commemorations for us. It is a time when we do mental arithmetic. My son Daniel died on June 11 last year. We became aware of his death on June 12, about 36 hours later. It was a Monday. I prayed three panikhidas that day. We found out about his death in the morning and I'd already had coffee, and I wasn't going to serve liturgy, but then I did. My wife wanted to go to Berlin immediately, but we found out that the first available flight would put us in Berlin on Wednesday. We celebrated liturgy on Tuesday, and then Marina our daughter Christina and I got on a plane, and eight hours later, with the eight-hour difference in time zones, we were in Berlin Wednesday morning. We just did what we did. It was a time of little sleep and very little fatigue. It was a time of much prayer every day.

We had been warned by the police that it could be two weeks before we were even able to see Daniel. We met with two detectives, and they were sympathetic, but they also had to do their jobs. They released Daniel's belonging to us - the ones that he left by the side of the river, intending to retrieve them after he swam across. It was a backpack with a few things in it. It had an icon of St. Daniel. I wept when I saw it. I was in a frenzy, pawing at things, looking for something, I'm not sure what. I remember the male detective looking confused, but he was respectful and just stayed out of the way. The icon was a great consolation to me. There was also an article that I'd written about St Porphyrios ("Let us start from somewhere else. The important thing was to start. A saying of Elder Porphyrios, and its application" - http://www.orthodox.net/full-voice/full-voice_2017+let-us-start-from-somewhere-else-the-important-thing-was-to-start.html) that Daniel must have picked up when he was at church before he departed for Germany that he had in his effects and had obviously read, and this was extremely comforting to me, although very overwhelming.

We met with Father Andrei, of the Russian Orthodox Church of the "Protection of the Mother of God", "Pokrov". It is on the Spree River. He was very kind, very helpful, very competent, and hooked us up with a funeral director who was very sympathetic to our needs. Beyond all expectations, Daniel's body was released the next day, and we were able to go to a private room and embrace him and pray for him and with him. There are pictures from that day, and I'm glad we have them, but I've never looked at them. Daniel had already been dead several days, but he looked like he was asleep. He didn't look dead. The only indication to the senses that he was dead was that he was not moving and that he was cool.

The next day, we went to the Spree River where Daniel died. When he drowned, the current carried him from the footbridge (Ebertbrücke) to the automobile bridge (Ravensbrück). Therefore, although we had received directions from his companion about where they jumped in (the Bode Museum was to their back, and the Ebertbrücke to their right), we thought, possibly because of the trauma, that he was mistaken and that they had actually jumped in near the Ravensbrück. So, we set up camp there and prayed a Panikhida and sang "More Honorable" in the way that Daniel loved it. We have a recording of that, and it is very raw.

Then came the weekend, and vigil, and I cannot even remember if I was there. I think I was. Of course, we had all kinds of arrangements to make for Daniel's remains to be shipped back. I celebrated liturgy the next day with Father Andrei, and it was very comforting to be able to pray at the altar and commemorate my son in the place where he died.

We arranged for his remains to be flown back on Wednesday afternoon, and for the funeral to be served on Thursday, after the liturgy, of course. I wouldn't dream of shortening anything or shortchanging my son. Vladyka Peter called me and told me that he was coming for the funeral and that I was to make no arrangements for him whatsoever. He was to arrive Thursday morning.

On Wednesday, when Daniel's plane was perhaps three hours away from landing, we found out that his remains were not on the plane. We made zillions of phone calls, and for some reason, this seemed like almost too much to take. We didn't know when we could serve the funeral, but it was certainly not going to be Thursday. Daniel had many friends from OU, and many were coming. All of Marina's doctors (she works as a nurse in an operating room and has a very close relationship with the pediatric doctors she works with) had shuttered their practice for Thursday, in order for all of them to attend. Now everything was in disarray.

It turned out that the plane that was flying out of Heathrow experienced some kind of terrorist scare. I believe they suspected that a bomb could be on the plane. They took all of the cargo – my son was cargo – off the plane and searched it. The flight had to leave within two hours of its scheduled time or be canceled. They didn't have enough time to get the cargo back on, but the passengers re-boarded and the flight took off with absolutely no baggage, and therefore no son. We did not know this until the plane was past midflight. The idea that the plane could've taken off with Daniel and exploded was difficult to contemplate, and it came unbidden to my mind.

We had to make many phone calls and arrange for Daniel's remains to come back on Thursday. I remember talking to the baggage handling service – my son was baggage – and being very insistent and even a little bit harsh with the man in charge so that there would not be another mess up. He was a fine, intelligent man and allowed me my space. I didn't cuss at him or anything, but I didn't bother trying to be too polite. On Thursday morning, I think at 5 AM, I woke him up and insisted that he be sure that Daniel was indeed on the plane. He was.

Archbishop Peter changed his arrangements to come on Friday. My dear friend and concelebrant, Archdeacon Sergius, whom I baptized and who has been a dear friend through these years, on his own, received a blessing and came to help with the funeral. Fr Sergius had been in the monastery for over a decade and had never traveled back home. His first trip back home was to help us.

When we prepared Daniel's body for the funeral, it was a (extended) family-only affair, but Father Sergius was there because he is family. This was time of prayer and intense activity, and I don't know what. The coffin had been built under the direction of my son Tim, with the help of everyone at home. It was an absolute work of art and of love. While we were in Germany working very hard, they were at home, working as hard. We didn't know it at the time, but the wood that my son-in-law Tim (another Tim, I call him Tim-3) used for the cross that was on Daniel's coffin was saved, and he made crosses for everyone and distributed them on the anniversary of his death. I treasure those crosses, and now one of them is on the altar table and I use it for blessing.

Daniel's funeral was Friday, after liturgy. I remember Vladyka Peter telling me that Father Nicholas should preach because I might have trouble. I agreed with him, but I had no intention whatsoever of having Father Nicholas preach. You know the old saying: "it's easier to get forgiveness than permission". When Father Nicholas was ready to preach, I took his place, because I had things to say ("Homily during the funeral of +Daniel Holland (06/11/2017 ns) By his father. Why do we pray for the dead? How do we remember the dead?" (http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/funeral_2017+daniel-holland.mp3, http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/funeral_2017+daniel-holland.html, [Word](#), [PDF](#))).

After the funeral was over, and we were preparing to go to the cemetery, which is at the "Nativity of our Lord Jesus Christ Monastery" in Kemp, Texas, we were nailing the cover on the coffin. Tim made sure it was made in the traditional way and there were absolutely no nails; we were using dowels. He pounded most of them, but I was standing on the northwest side of the coffin by Daniel's head, and I pounded the last one in. I remember the rhythm of the nailing: "Bam .. Bam Bam Bam ... Bam". And after I finished, there was another "Bam". The sound was not from my hammer, but it was from an icon of the "Harrowing of Hell" falling off the iconostasis and hitting the floor. In front of that icon was an icon lamp, and then a stand, and

then a plant. The icon missed all those things, because it actually moved away from the wall and then fell. There are witnesses who saw this happen.

It turns out that one of Daniel's dear friends, Ramzi, made a secret prayer moments before in which she said to God: "Please show me some sign that he's all right". She even said, "Maybe take one of those pictures off the wall there". She admitted this later, and thought she was in trouble, and had possibly been disrespectful. God answered her prayer and ours and gave us great consolation. Of course, if the icon had been the "Last Judgment", it would not have been such a consolation, but it was the icon of "The Harrowing of Hell", the so-called "Resurrection Icon".

Immediately after this amazing incident, I received a phone call from the fiancée of one of the men I take care of in prison. I had baptized Ignatius and had a close relationship with him. His son David died of his own hand, 10 days (June 21) after Daniel died. I was finding out a couple of days after that. His sister, Tawnya and his fiancée, Jennifer, were planning to go to the prison to tell him, and I knew that I had to go also.

I wanted to continue the traditional 40 consecutive liturgies for Daniel, which I had started the day before his funeral, but now I would not be celebrating liturgy on the day after his funeral, Saturday, because I would be traveling to a prison to tell a friend that his son was also dead. When we were in Berlin we were not able to celebrate liturgy, except on Sunday. Once I got home I celebrated liturgy every day until the funeral, and of course on the day of the funeral. But now the string was broken, and I, being Irish and not all that smart and very stubborn, was definitely going to serve 40 consecutive liturgies in a row. I was also in the midst of going to prisons and celebrating liturgy, in June when it is beastly hot in some of the prisons. God give me the strength to do this, because He loves fools.

On the way to the monastery, instead of praying the "Jesus prayer" as I had planned, I made a zillion phone calls and got permission to go to the prison on what is normally a family-only visitation day.

The visitation room is a room that absolutely pulsates with happiness. Prisoners and their families are sitting at tables, and everyone is smiling, and I swear that you can actually see the happiness. Adjacent to this room is a small room with vending machines. The visitors come with a lot of change and buy soft drinks and snacks. We were waiting in the small room, and Ignatius had to walk through the room full of happiness to see us. Normally, we would be in that room waiting for him; instead, we were in the adjacent room. As soon as he saw me, he started to weep, because I was the canary in the coal mine. I was the thing that didn't belong there. There must be a reason why I was there and it couldn't be a good reason. The warden was very concerned that Ignatius might react badly to his son's death, and possibly even become violent. Of course, he must always be concerned about security, so he was present, but out of the way. For the first 10 minutes, we just embraced tightly and cried, and of course, we had to tell him. The warden had told us that I only had 10 or 15 minutes with him and then I had to leave, but I believe we were in that room for 40 minutes. Finally, the warden told me that I had to go, and Ignatius continued to talk to his sister and fiancé. And then there was a two and half hour drive home, and vigil, and liturgy the next day, the first of Daniel's 40 liturgies.

When I think back about all the things that went on, I can understand why throughout this year I have felt so tired. I don't mean physically tired. But this year, wonderful things have happened, and we have seen God's grace and love in ways that cannot be fully explained.

I know for certain that I would not have met one man in prison if not for the death of Daniel. Scotty had also lost a son, to an accident and criminal neglect after the accident. Scotty was not doing well. Because I, despite my sins, have a few tools, and

have a certain approach to death and to grief that is unique and revelatory to many people, Ignatius was getting some help. (For example, see "Using the Energy in Grief.. Talk given at the St Herman Youth Conference, December, 2017, Kansas City"

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/misc_2017+using-the-energy-in-grief+st-herman-youth-conference.doc, also [AUDIO](#)) He in turn was speaking to his friend Scotty. Scotty didn't know anything about Orthodoxy, and didn't particularly have an interest in it, but he needed consolation so he came to see me. Shortly after I met Scotty, Ignatius was shipped to another unit, which was a great sadness for both of us (it took me three months or more, I think, to traverse the Byzantine tangle that is TDCJ prison administration, and get permission to go to the unit Ignatius is now in. I now go to that unit twice a month). I was afraid that Scotty might stop coming because Ignatius was no longer around, but he kept coming, and we kept talking about grief and about the energy of grief and about the meaning of life, and about our sons. Now Scotty desires to become an Orthodox Christian and I will make him a catechumen soon. It is hard to describe to you the depth that I have in several personal relationships in prisons.

Marina and I have formed strong relationships with several people who have also experienced grief because of the loss of their children. We have an ongoing correspondence with many of them. We pray for their children and they pray for our son. I have a gigantic list called Daniel's list (<http://www.orthodox.net/daniel/dyptichs-daniels-list.html>) of the people who pray for Daniel and also those who have lost their lives in a sudden way. My offering to Daniel is that I pray from this list every day.

Just this past Thursday, June 21, was the anniversary of David's death. I went to the Eastham unit to remember David together with Ignatius. We prayed one of the kneeling prayers from Pentecost, some short troparia for the dead, and then Ignatius prayed a prayer for his son which I had found on the Internet, and that I use every day (<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/prayer-for-a-child-who-has-fallen-asleep.html>) (also [PDF](#), [DOC](#)). After that, we had coffee and baklava and talked about our sons and about things that matter.

Of course, we are in the middle of fast, but in prison you must be flexible. If anyone's offended about that, I personally don't care. I try to bring food on non-fasting days, but by my visitation day is usually on Wednesday so there are only a few non-fasting days throughout the year. Generally, on those days that I bring food and it is a fasting day I don't eat anything, but just drink coffee. Nobody has ever noticed, because I'm busy serving. In this case, there were only four of us, so there wasn't a lot of need to do any serving. Deacon David (Companik, a colleague in orthodox prison ministry, and soon to be ordained a priest, so that we will have three priests that I know of in Texas who are regularly visiting prisons) and I had two pieces of baklava each, and left the rest for 2 hungry inmates, and 2 trustees who worked in the chapel to devour. It was the right thing to do, and so we did it. I tell you truthfully, after the two pieces, I wanted more.

I just finished a three-day prison trip, coming home on Friday. In that trip, I baptized a man, made another man a catechumen, commemorated the death of a son, and visited five prisons, and drove 520 miles. Today is Saturday, the day after the trip, and the same day, a year ago, when we buried my son.

After this letter, I will commemorate everyone in Daniel's list, and move on to the rest of my day. Sometimes it feels like a river that is just rushing down, and if you ever been in a river you know it's pretty hard to turn around, but because of our memory, once in a while I turn around.

This document:

<http://www.orthodox.net/daniel/a-year-after-daniels-funeral-and-burial.pdf> <http://www.orthodox.net/daniel/a-year-after-daniels-funeral-and-burial.doc>

Priest Seraphim Holland seraphim@orthodox.net